What Uber, Ola and Rapido riders actually complain about

Pranav Thatavarti · 80,548 real Play Store reviews, India, English, 20 Jul to 19 Oct 2026 · pulled 20 Oct 2026

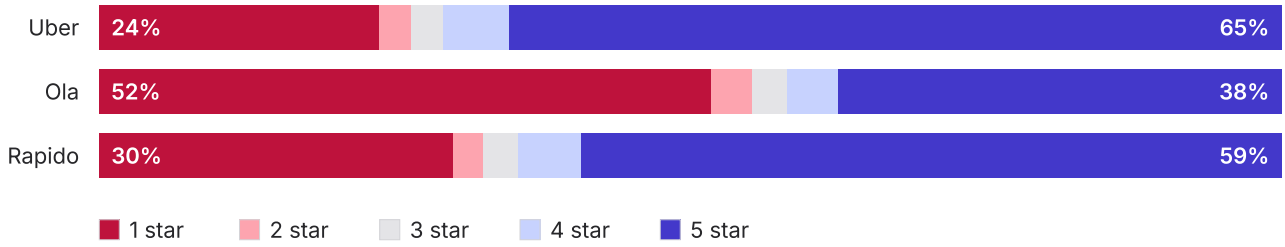
I wanted to know what goes wrong on a ride in India, in riders' own words. Not from a survey. So I pulled every English review from the India Play Store for the three big apps over the last three months.

Then I took 3,000 random reviews per app and tagged each one with the main reason behind it, from a fixed list of 15 themes. An LLM did the tagging. I checked 50 of its tags by hand.

App	Play Store ID	Reviews in 3 months	1 star	5 star	Tagged
Uber	com.ubercab	41,073	23.7%	65.4%	3,000
Ola	com.olacabs.customer	3,754	51.8%	37.5%	3,000
Rapido	com.rapido.passenger	35,721	29.9%	59.3%	3,000

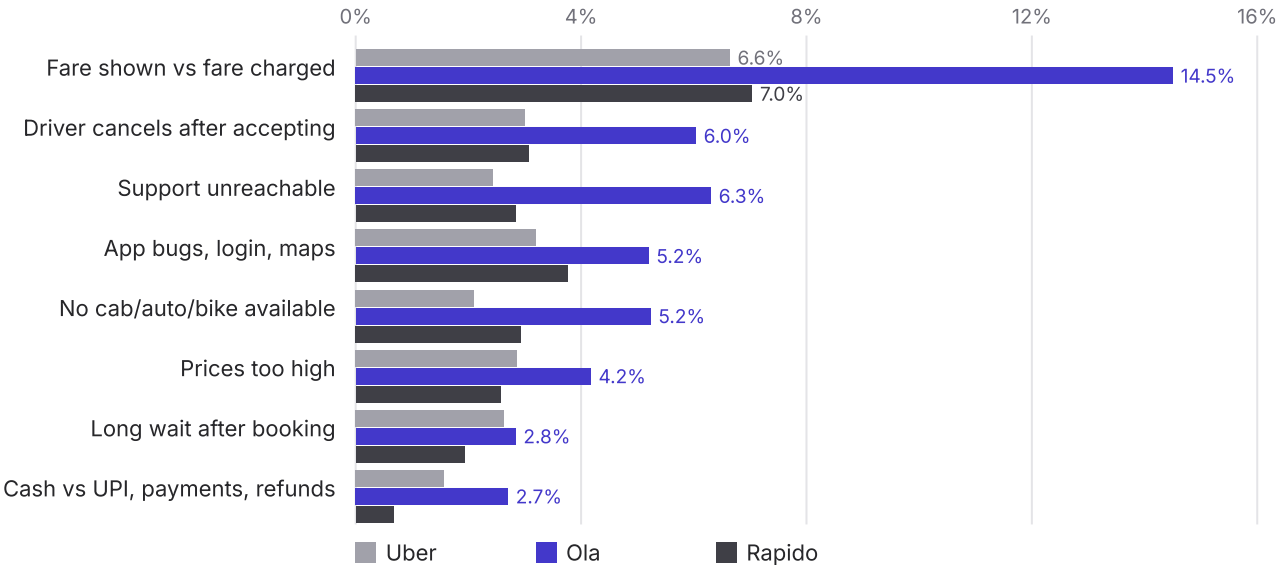
> The same problem tops all three apps: the fare I'm charged isn't the fare I was shown. On Ola it's more than double the rate on Uber or Rapido.

Star split of written reviews



All reviews in the window. Play shows 4.6 to 4.7 stars for all three, but that average includes star-only ratings. People who bother to write are angrier.

Complaint themes, share of each app's reviews



Share of 3,000 random reviews per app. Praise, vague complaints and off-topic reviews make up the rest. Full table in the spreadsheet.

Top 3 complaints per app, with a real review each

Verbatim. Phone numbers, UPI IDs and number plates masked, no names. "Vague or other complaint" ("worst app") is left out of the top 3.

Uber

Fare shown vs fare charged	6.6%	*"while Booking showing some rate and when we reach destination showing increased rate by more than 20%"*
App bugs, login, maps	3.2%	*"The amount of ads, pop-ups and annoying offers is extremely high. The app is poorly designed, and hardly intuitive."*
Driver cancels or refuses after accepting	3.0%	*"Drivers who cancels should have a fine as well for accepting then cancelling.. been dealing with it everytime."*

Ola

Fare shown vs fare charged	14.5%	*"very bad experience i booked a bike ride showing a fare of 122, but after the Trip was completed , it increased to 180 and ..."*
Support unreachable	6.3%	*"dumbest app, doesn't allow you to contact customer support... The driver has collected extra money but I'm unable to report ..."*
Driver cancels or refuses after accepting	6.0%	*"After accepting the ride, the driver did not come and he was telling me to cancel the ride. if he didn't want to come then ..."*

Rapido

Fare shown vs fare charged	7.0%	*"pathetic app, the drivers won't confirm ride untill you increase the amount to 40-50 rupees on the app i had to wait for ..."*
App bugs, login, maps	3.8%	*"Very Bad App Performance. Works very slow, and gets stuck often. Ride fares increase between the Rides. Worst and ..."*
Driver cancels or refuses after accepting	3.1%	*"Your app is taking very long time to confirm the ride and Your captains after confirming the ride are most of the time ..."*

Does the tagging hold up?

I drew 50 tagged reviews at random and labelled each one myself before looking at the model's answer.

- Exact match on the theme: **42 of 50 (84%)**.
- Same direction (complaint, praise or unclear): **48 of 50 (96%)**.

The misses were mostly neighbours. "Takes hours to confirm a ride" went to wait time; I'd call it availability. Two were reviews from outside India. Good enough to rank themes, not to quote to one decimal. With only 50 checks, true agreement could be roughly 71% to 92% (estimate, Wilson 95% interval).

Things to keep in mind

- One theme per review. A cancel followed by bad support counts once, as a cancel.
- English only. Hindi and Telugu reviewers who write in their own script are mostly missing.
- Play's India feed for Uber isn't purely Indian. 72 of the 3,000 Uber reviews mention dollars, euros or foreign places.
- Ola's volume is small. It got 3,754 written reviews in three months, about one for every 11 on Uber.
- Reviews over-represent bad days. They show what hurts, not how often per trip.

Method: google-play-scraper (lang=en, country=in, newest first), random sample of 3,000 per app (seed 42), tagged by Claude Sonnet in batches of 40 against fixed theme definitions, plus a second pass that splits fare complaints by what happened. Script, theme list and every tagged review are in the files.

What I'd fix first

Ola: the fare on the screen should be the fare I pay

The problem

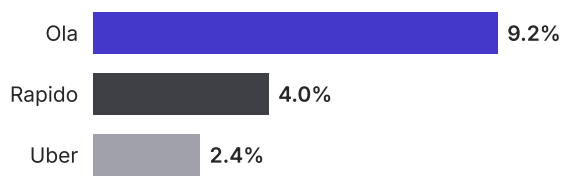
A rider books an Ola at Kacheguda station in Hyderabad. The app says ₹550. The driver turns up and wants ₹800, or cancel. The rider cancels, and Ola charges a ₹50 cancel fee. That's one real review. 277 of the 3,000 Ola reviews I sampled tell some version of it: accept, ask for more, and then nobody at Ola to complain to.

This isn't surge. It's a driver asking for more than the app fare after accepting. It's fixable because Ola controls the fare, the payment and the payout.

Evidence

- Fare complaints are 14.5% of Ola's reviews, vs 6.6% on Uber and 7.0% on Rapido.
- Inside those, 277 of 3,000 Ola reviews (9.2%) are a driver asking for more than the app fare. 238 of the 277 are 1 star.
- Ola's #2 complaint is support unreachable (6.3%). So the rider gets squeezed and then has nowhere to go.

Driver asked for more than the app fare



Out of 3,000 sampled reviews per app

> *"I used to be a routine Ola user for many years, but I will not use the app again because of this "popular fare" garbage. I'm not at a local market where a popular rate is given and then I have to haggle with a driver to fix the price. The Ola team ..."*

> *"We book ola based on the fare shown on the app. It is highly unprofessional to accept the booking and then call us demanding extra money because the destination is "far" or saying they will charge by ..."*

The fix: a fare guarantee

- **One button on the trip screen: "Driver asked for more".** It's there from the moment a driver accepts until 24 hours after the trip.
- **I pay the app fare. Ola pays back the rest.** If I paid extra, it goes back to my UPI or Ola Money within a day, up to a cap. Ola recovers it from the driver's payout after a check.
- **Acceptance means the fare.** A cancel right after a call to the rider costs the driver more than a normal cancel. If he won't do the trip at that fare, the time to say so is before accepting.

Where AI helps, and where it doesn't. The button and the guarantee need no AI. AI earns its place in two spots. First, triage: riders will report in Hindi, Telugu or English, by text or voice note. A model reads the report next to the trip data (fare, route, a call before pickup, a cash switch at the end) and approves the refund when it's clear. It can say yes. Only a person can say no, same rule I use in my claims work. Second, repeat drivers: a simple model flags drivers with a pattern of reports and cancel-after-call, so ops coach or suspend the few causing most of it. I would not record or transcribe calls.

How I'd measure it

- Share of Ola reviews tagged "driver asked for more". Baseline 9.2% from this data. Target: half that in two quarters (estimate). I'd re-run this same script monthly.
- Reports per 1,000 trips. I expect it to rise at first, because reporting gets easy. That's fine.
- Cancels within 2 minutes of a driver-to-rider call.
- Median time to refund. Target under 24 hours (estimate).
- Guardrails: driver acceptance rate, driver churn, refund cost per trip, share of audited refunds that were false.

Risks

- Drivers may ask for more because the fare really is too low for them, especially on short auto trips. Policing alone could cut acceptance. I'd review fares for short trips at the same time.
- Riders could abuse refunds. Cap per trip and per month, and audit a sample.
- Auto meter rules differ by city. Pune reviewers say drivers insist on the meter. Legal needs to sign off city by city.
- My evidence is reviews, not trip logs. The real per-trip rate is unknown. The first four weeks of button data would give the true baseline.

All numbers from the review sample described on page 1 unless marked as an estimate.